

Priced PLEASURES

In a country where sex is still talked about in hushed tones, sex at a cost is rampant, with nearly one in every five men having visited a prostitute at least once

Do you approve of paid sex?

YES 16 NO **84**

Male 24, Female 9

Male 76, Female 91

All figures in per cent

Nine per cent of the females had no problems in having sex with male prostitutes and this is highest in four metros (Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata and Chennai)

How often have you paid to have sex?

		Male	Female
All the time	15	15	9
Sometimes	42	42	47
Rarely	40	40	30
Never	4	3	15

For 551 respondents of the total of 5,353 who say they have had sex with a prostitute. The figures have been rounded-off to the nearest integer. All figures in per cent.

DEAR AFFAIR

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PER CENT ENGAGED URBAN INDIANS APPROVED OF PAID SEX COMPARED TO 17 PER CENT OF MARRIED PEOPLE.

By Swagata Sen

Samantha Jones, the woman who was always out there, almost always had the best lines in the 1990s hit series, *Sex & The City*, said, "Money is power. Sex is power. Therefore money for sex is an exchange of power." But that was 10 years ago, and it was New York. In India, the screws are so tightened, metaphorically speaking, that paying for sex is all about getting on the wrong side of the powers that be. But with the unavailability of a free sexual atmosphere, paid sex remains an easy way to access forbidden pleasures.

All around us, money and sexual pleasures exchange themselves, some overtly, some a little sophisticated in their sales pitch. On the one hand are gyrating music videos that reach to us in our drawing rooms, and then there are these crude versions of pay for porn in every self-respecting electrified village in India masquerading as an innocuous video parlour, giving adolescents their first taste of the nether world. There are phone calls you can make and unknowingly pay a bomb for husky voices to ask you what you're wearing, and there are cruder variations of *Playboy* selling in city sidewalks in plastic covers, ensuring that you have to pay even if you want to look.

Author Bill Bryson, in his book about his

